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NATIONAL SECURITY COUNCIL
WASHINGTON, D.C. 20506

MEMORANDUM OF CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: The President's Telephone Conversation with
Argentine President Raul Alfonsin

PARTICIPANTS: The President
Stephanie Van Reigersberg (State Department,
Translator)
David Pacelli (NSC, Notetaker)

DATE, TIME May 13, 1989, 6:38 p.m. - 6:51 p.m.
AND PLACE: Air Force One at Columbus Air Force Base,
Mississippi - Presidential Residence

The President initiated the call from his aircraft which was on the ground at Columbus Air Force Base.

The President began by saying, "How are you, sir?"

President Alfonsin said he was delighted to hear from the President, asking, "How are you?"

The President said he was fine. He said he was calling from his airplane which was on the ground; he hoped the connection was good.

President Alfonsin said that he could hear very well.

The President said he first wanted to convey his respects and to simply ask for any thoughts President Alfonsin might have on Panama. The President said he had been talking to various other leaders and was happy to have the opportunity to talk to President Alfonsin. He said he recognized the need for other leaders to be taking the lead for solutions in Panama. He added that he wanted President Alfonsin to know that we are looking for the OAS meeting to be successful. If you have any ideas or advice, he said, please tell me in the spirit of consultations. The President said he was very sensitive to the United States not being dominant in the search for a solution with respect to democracy in Panama. The President again asked if President Alfonsin had any thoughts to share on the subject.

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President Alfonsin said that he agreed ["coincido"] with the President's thoughts on Panama. He thought that we would be able to work together for a solution in the OAS, saying that he believed the meeting would take place on Wednesday. President Alfonsin stated that he thought the meeting would be very important. Monday, he and his foreign minister would be in Asuncion for the Paraguayan presidential inauguration. He hoped to get the opportunity to speak to U.S. State Department people there and to come up with some suggestions. He would be delighted to call the President and discuss his ideas.

The President said he appreciated that and said he would contact U.S. officials attending the inauguration. The President said, incidentally, his daughter would be in the U.S. delegation at Asuncion. The reason for that is to convey in a personal way our commitment to democracy in Paraguay. He added, "If you see a beautiful girl in our delegation, it is my daughter, Dorothy."

President Alfonsin said, "Good, I'll have the pleasure of giving her a kiss."

The President said that he appreciated that. The President asked President Alfonsin to telephone him after the visit or send a written message with his thoughts, whichever was easier.

The President continued by saying that he wanted to raise a last point, some remarks he made to the press today. "I said that if Noriega left Panama" there would be an instant normalization of relations. The President also stated that he had said there could be a useful role for the Panama Defense Forces in the future. There is nothing in the Noriega problem which is a repudiation of the Panama Defense Force as an institution. Of course, he said, we want to see the recognition of Endara as the legitimate victor of the election. "I made a public statement, not in an inflammatory way, so that the people will know that there can be an instant betterment of relations with the United States, including the lifting of sanctions and improvement in economic relations as well."

President Alfonsin said it seemed like a very intelligent statement. It opens the path to negotiations that can be fruitful. Anything I can get, he said, I will call you. President Alfonsin said, in reality, it seemed that Panama is a special case. Noriega's actions are anti-democratic, but the "moral aspect" is important as well.

The President thanked President Alfonsin for his comments and said he appreciated Alfonsin's leadership. He wished President Alfonsin all the best, told Alfonsin of his respect for him, and asked him to please call with his ideas.

President Alfonsin thanked the President, saying he was very kind. He sent his warmest greeting to Mrs. Bush.

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The President said he would, adding that she is doing very well. He repeated that he would convey Alfonsin's good wishes and said good bye, whereupon the conversation was concluded.

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WHITE HOUSE CABLE

SUBJECT: Presidential Telephone Calls to Presidents Sanguinetti, Alfonsin, and Garcia on May 13

The following should be distributed to Ambassadors only in Montevideo, Buenos Aires, Lima, and Asuncion, and the head of the U.S. delegation to the Rodriguez inauguration, Mrs. Dorothy Bush.

The President telephoned Presidents Sanguinetti, Alfonsin, and Garcia on May 13 between 6 p.m. and 7:45 p.m. EDT to discuss the situation in Panama. All three calls were made from Air Force One, the first two while on the ground at Columbus Air Force Base, Mississippi and the Garcia call shortly after takeoff from that location.

The President solicited the views of each leader and asked each if there was anything that we could or should do. He emphasized that he valued consultations and was trying to avoid acting alone in this case. In all three conversations, the President referred to a statement he gave to a press conference on Air Force One while enroute to Mississippi for a speech (SEPTTEL). All three recipients of the calls welcomed the consultation in warm terms and indicated a willingness to follow up by maintaining contact with the President. The only other subject discussed in the conversations was the President's noting that the pretty woman in the U.S. delegation to the Rodriguez inauguration was his daughter. She was sent to indicate his personal interest in Paraguayan democracy.

In the conversation with Sanguinetti (21 minutes), the President indicated that the OAS might take action now as it did in 1979 when it paved the way for the downfall of Somoza. The President stated that we would like to see recognition of Endara as victor in the election. Sanguinetti agreed on the necessity of maintaining pressure on Noriega. Although he was favorable to recognizing Endara, he did not have a definitive position on an OAS resolution and did not know if a consensus could be reached. From a practical standpoint, he wondered if recognition would solve anything, since we would have a new situation like that of Delvalle. Sanguinetti briefly commented that we would need a mechanism of negotiation at some point, although not before the OAS session.

The President summarized his press statement: if Noriega leaves Panama, we would instantly normalize relations and lift the sanctions. We also said that he had stated that we had no quarrel with the Panama Defense Force as an institution; it could have a useful role in the future. Sanguinetti regarded this as a good and useful statement. He suggested that the U.S. approach Mexico since it was an obstacle to consensus. The President said he did not know the degree to which Mexico would be receptive given its historical position on this issue.

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In the conversation with President Alfonsin (13 minutes), Alfonsin said that he agreed with the President's thoughts on Panama. He hoped to be able to talk to State Department representatives attending the Rodriguez inauguration. The President said he would contact them with the results of his conversation.

Alfonsin called the President's statement to the press "a very intelligent statement." He also noted, "It opens the path to negotiations which can be fruitful." He made no specific comment on endorsing Endara or on the content of an OAS resolution.

The President's call to President Garcia was the longest (26 minutes). Garcia said he was following the President's comments very carefully. He regarded Endara as the legitimate winner of the election. He saw the necessity for the United States and the Group of Eight to have more pressures on Panama in the OAS, but he did not volunteer any specifics on an OAS resolution.

Garcia apparently was under the impression that U.S. military measures in Panama were imminent. He suggested that the President let the situation mature a bit, since his information was that there were splits in the Panama Defense Forces. He urged the President to wait a few days. The President replied that he had no early expectation of military action unless U.S. citizens were jeopardized. Then, he would have a responsibility to protect them. He referred to watching Noriega's thugs on television, saying that it demonstrated the need for his decision to send U.S. reinforcements.

Garcia also warned about a Noriega provocation to force the governments of the hemisphere to line up with him. Nevertheless, he trusted in the good judgment of the President to avoid overreaction. He commented that the events in Panama had an irreversible course, for they awakened the thirst for democracy; the President agreed.

In his reference to the press statement, the President also stated in the Garcia conversation that it would be a good thing if Noriega went to a country with which the United States did not have an extradition treaty. Garcia thought the President's remarks to be well thought out and precise. Although he agreed it was correct to separate out U.S. opposition to Noriega from its position toward the Defense Forces, he advised that it would be better to say nothing more about what will happen to Noriega himself. His second suggestion was that the United States ensure that its policy be put in a broader context of support for democracy everywhere in the hemisphere, not just support for democracy in a country where the United States has a historical and specific interest.